The Great Northern Plains

This fertile plain lies to the south of the northern mountains. This plain is one of the most extensive stretches of the alluvium in the world and is deposited by the rivers Indus, Ganga, Brahmaputra and their tributaries. The length of the plain is about 2,400 km and the width varies from 240 to 320 km. Its width increases from east to west. It covers an area of over 7 lakh sq.km.

The Great Plains of India is remarkably a homogeneous surface with an imperceptible slope. They are formed mostly by the depositional process of the Himalayan and Vindhyan rivers. These rivers deposit enormous quantity of sediments deposited along the foothills and flood plains. The important characteristics featuress of sediment deposition in the plains areas as follows.

a) The Bhabar Plain

This plain is made up of gravels and unassorted sediments deposited by the Himalayan rivers. The porosity of this plain is so high that most of the small streams flow over this region disappear. Its width varies from 8 to 15 km. It is wider in the western plains (Jammu Division) than in the east (Assam). This plain is not suitable for cultivation, only big trees with large roots thrive in this region.

b) The Tarai Tract

It is a zone of excessive dampness, thick forests and rich wild life. This tract lies to the south of Bhabar plains. The width of this belt is 15-30 km. The Tarai is wider in the eastern parts of the Great Plains, especially in Brahmaputra Valley due to heavy rainfall. In many states, the Tarai forests have been cleared for cultivation.

c) The Bhangar Plains

The Bhangar represent the upland alluvial tracts of the Great Plains of India, formed by the older alluviums. The Bhangar land lies above the flood limits of the rivers. This soil is dark in colour, rich in humus content, well drained and useful for agriculture.

d) The Khadar Plains

The new alluvium tracts along the courses of the rivers are known as the 'Khadar' or 'Bet' lands. The Khadar tracts are enriched by fresh deposits of silt every year during rainy seasons. The Khadar land consists of sand, silt, clay and mud. It is highly fertile soil.

e) Delta

Triangle shaped fertile land at the mouth of Ganga and Brahmaputhra rivers is called as the Sundarban delta. It is the biggest and fastest growing delta. It is an area of deposition as the river flows in this tract sluggishly. The deltaic plain consists mainly of old mud, new mud and marsh. In the delta region, the uplands are called '**Chars**' while the marshy areas are called '**Bils**'.

On the basis of deposition of sediments by various rivers and topographical characteristics, the Northern Plains of India is divided into the following four major regions:

1) **Rajasthan Plains:** It is located to the west of Aravalli range. It covers an area of about 1,75,000 sq.km. Rajasthan plain is formed by the deposition of the river Luni and the long vanished river Saraswathi. There are several salt lakes in Rajasthan. The Sambhar salt lake (Pushkar Lake) near Jaipur is the prominent one.

   The Thar desert, also known as the Great Indian desert is a large arid region in the north western part of the Indian subcontinent that covers an area of 2,00,000 km^2 and forms a natural boundary between India and Pakistan. It is the world 7th largest desert.

   The desert lies in the western part of the aravalli range and covers 2/3 of Rajastan state. There are two major divisions in the Thar desert. They are known as the Actual desert region (Marusthali) and the semi desert region (Bhangar). Many different types of sand dunes and salt lakes (Dhands) are seen here.

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